

■ By Priya Sahgal, Swagata Sen and Satarupa Bhattacharjya

Exile is another country, where time rusts and life stagnates. And where homecoming is a permanent state of mind. Ask Taslima Nasreen, whose life at the moment is a heavily protected passage through the safe houses of the government. First condemned by a paranoid religion that abhors questions and banishes blasphemers, she has now become the centre of a political whirl. Abandoned by the highest priests of secular politics for a few votes from the minority ghettos, she has only one definitive offer of political asylum and that is from Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi. The politics that is being played around Nasreen continues to be as underwhelming as her writing.

Her ejection from the heartland of secular politics, Buddhadeb Bhattacharya's Kolkata, was the first shock. In retrospect, the Marxists, already scalded by Nandigram, could not have done anything better: secular in their lexicon means indulging the Muslim vote bank. So when sundry Islamist groups swarmed the streets and flames of communal rage lit up a volatile city, the communist government told her without any dialectical ambiguity: Kolkata can't be your home any longer. She was sent to BJP-ruled Rajasthan; unwanted in Kolkata, she became the protected in right-wing Jaipur—and the hottest political item in India after the nuclear deal. Vasundhara Raje's Rajasthan government played host when she reached Delhi as well. Now she is in one of those Intelligence Bureau safe houses. As Nasreen, a writer of little literary consequence, becomes invisible, the politics of Nasreen the exile gets blatant.

The Congress, like the communists, is suddenly selectively secular. Careful not to antagonise the comrades and alienate the Muslim vote bank on the morning of the crucial nuclear debate in Parliament, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee told the House that "throughout history, India has never refused shelter to those who have sought our protection.... India will continue to provide shelter to Nasreen." However, the assurance came with



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1994	Lajja banned in Dhaka; put under house arrest; flees to Sweden	2004	Moves to Kolkata, requests for Indian citizenship	2005	Booted off the stage while attempting to read an anti-war poem to a large Bengali crowd at Madison Square Garden, New York	2007	AUGUST 9 Attacked in Hyderabad; West Bengal pressures her to leave Kolkata as well as country	NOVEMBER 15	All India Minorities Front burns her effigies in Kolkata
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